ADVANCED 4 — READING & GRAMMAR REVIEW

Name: _____

TEXT 1 — THE YEAR WITHOUT A SUMMER

[1] In April 1815, Mount Tambora, a volcano on the Indonesian island of Sumbawa, exploded in the most powerful eruption in recorded history. The sound of the explosion was heard more than 2,000 kilometers away. By the time the ash settled, around 10,000 people had died, and entire villages had been buried under rock and burning mud. Yet the worst consequences were not felt until the following year, and they were felt thousands of kilometers away, by people who had never heard of Sumbawa.

[2] The eruption had thrown enormous quantities of sulfur gas high into the atmosphere. There, the gas formed a thin veil that reflected sunlight back into space. Scientists now estimate that the cloud of gas spread around the entire planet within a few months. As a result, average global temperatures dropped by almost half a degree Celsius. This might not sound dramatic, but when temperatures fall even slightly, growing seasons become shorter and crops fail. In 1816, snow was reported in New England in June, and frost was recorded in every summer month. Farmers who had planted corn in May watched helplessly as it died in the fields.

[3] Europe suffered even more. Cold rain fell across Britain, France and Germany for weeks, and harvests were destroyed. Food prices rose sharply, and hungry crowds attacked markets and grain stores in several cities. Bread became so expensive that ordinary families could no longer afford it, and governments feared that hunger would lead to revolution. In Switzerland, the authorities had to organize emergency food supplies for thousands of families. Many people stopped to farm altogether and left their villages in search of work, while others sold everything they owned and emigrated to America.

[4] Strangely, nobody at the time understood what was happening. Scientists had not yet connected volcanic eruptions to changes in climate, and news from Asia took months to reach Europe. If people had known about Tambora, they would have understood that the cold was only temporary. Instead, many believed that the sun was dying or that the end of the world had arrived. Some preachers even told their congregations that the cold was a punishment from God. The link between the eruption and the terrible weather was not established until the twentieth century, when researchers began studying ice cores and old weather records.

[5] The cold summer also left a cultural mark. That June, a group of young writers was staying at a villa near Lake Geneva. Because the weather was too stormy to go outside, they decided to hold a competition: who could write the most frightening story? One of them, eighteen-year-old Mary Shelley, began writing *Frankenstein*. If the summer had been sunny, she might never have created her famous monster, and one of the most influential novels in English literature would not exist today. The same competition produced another famous work, John Polidori's *The Vampyre*, which helped to create a whole new kind of fiction. Tambora reminds us that a single event in one corner of the world can change history everywhere, even the history of books.

Reading Comprehension

Choose the best answer (A, B, C or D) according to the text.

1. According to paragraph 2, why did temperatures drop in 1816?

A) Volcanic ash blocked rivers and lakes.

B) Cold rain fell for many weeks.

C) Sulfur gas formed a layer that reflected sunlight.

D) The volcano released cold air into the atmosphere.

2. The word “veil” in paragraph 2 is closest in meaning to:

A) covering **B)** storm

C) opening **D)** current

3. According to paragraph 3, all of the following happened in Europe EXCEPT:

A) Harvests were destroyed.

B) Bread became too expensive for many families.

C) Some people left their villages to find work.

D) The Swiss government closed its borders.

4. What can be inferred from paragraph 4 about people in 1816?

A) They blamed Indonesia for the weather.

B) They lacked the scientific knowledge to explain the cold.

C) They did not notice the change in temperature.

D) They expected another eruption soon.

5. Why does the author mention Mary Shelley in paragraph 5?

A) To show that Tambora’s effects reached culture as well as agriculture

B) To criticize writers who ignored the crisis

C) To explain where *Frankenstein* was first published

D) To compare the weather in Britain and Switzerland

Grammar in the Text

Answer the questions about the grammar used in the text. Choose the best option or write your answer on the lines.

6. **Find the mistake.** Paragraph 3 contains one mistake with a verb pattern (gerund or infinitive). Find it and correct it.

Mistake: _____ Correction: _____

7. **Same meaning.** Which sentence has the same meaning as “If people had known about Tambora, they would have understood that the cold was only temporary” (paragraph 4)?

A) People knew about Tambora, so they understood the cold was temporary.

B) People didn’t know about Tambora, so they didn’t understand that the cold was temporary.

C) If people know about Tambora, they will understand the cold.

D) People understood the cold was temporary, although they didn’t know about Tambora.

8. **Find it.** One sentence in paragraph 5 mixes a past condition with a present result. Copy the part that refers to the present.

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9. **Rewrite.** Rewrite in the passive: “Hungry crowds attacked markets and grain stores in several cities.”

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10. **Choose.** “By the time the ash settled, around 10,000 people had died” (paragraph 1). What does the past perfect show?

A) The deaths continued after the ash settled.

B) The deaths and the settling happened at the same moment.

C) The deaths happened before the ash settled.

D) The deaths are still happening.

TEXT 2 — THE DOOMSDAY VAULT

[1] Deep inside a mountain on the Norwegian island of Spitsbergen, about 1,300 kilometers from the North Pole, lies one of the most important buildings on Earth. The Svalbard Global Seed Vault, which opened in 2008, stores more than a million samples of seeds from almost every country in the world. It was built so that humanity could recover from any disaster that might destroy farms on a large scale. Journalists like to call it the "Doomsday Vault," although the people who manage it prefer a less dramatic name. The vault is not open to the public.

[2] The idea behind the vault is simple: seeds are a kind of insurance. Every crop we eat, from rice to potatoes, exists in thousands of varieties, and each variety has different strengths. Some survive long periods without rain; others resist particular diseases. If a variety disappears, the genetic information it carries disappears with it. Unfortunately, old varieties are lost every year, whereas new ones can take decades to develop. A variety of wheat that seems useless today could one day be the only one able to grow in a hotter climate. Wars, floods and simple human errors have already destroyed several national seed collections.

[3] The location was chosen carefully. Svalbard, where the ground stays frozen all year, provides natural cooling, albeit not quite enough. The vault is kept at minus eighteen degrees Celsius, so machines help the frozen rock do its job. The seeds are sealed in special packets, which keep out moisture. At that temperature, seeds stay alive far longer than they would in a normal storeroom. The building also sits 130 meters above sea level in order that the seeds will stay dry even if the polar ice melts completely.

[4] Countries do not give their seeds away. A deposit works like a safe-deposit box in a bank: the vault holds the boxes, but only the country that sent them can open them. Most countries have never needed to withdraw their seeds, but one has. In 2015, during the war in Syria, researchers who had worked at a seed bank near Aleppo asked for their samples back. They planted them in Lebanon and Morocco, harvested new seeds and later returned them to Svalbard. It was the first withdrawal in the vault's history. In this way, a collection that the war had almost destroyed was rebuilt.

[5] The vault has had its own problems, however. In 2017, unusually warm weather melted part of the frozen ground, and water entered the entrance tunnel. No seeds were damaged, but the incident was an uncomfortable warning: a building that had been designed to survive climate change had been affected by it. The tunnel was repaired and made waterproof lest a similar flood happen again. Today, the vault is still far from full, and new deposits arrive several times a year. The food security is a challenge that no single nation can solve alone, and this quiet mountain in the Arctic is one of the clearest examples of countries working together for the future.

Reading Comprehension

Choose the best answer (A, B, C or D) according to the text.

1. According to paragraph 1, why was the vault built?

A) To sell rare seeds to farmers

B) To help humanity recover if farms were destroyed on a large scale

C) To attract tourists to the Arctic

D) To replace national seed collections

2. The word “it” in paragraph 2 (“disappears with it”) refers to:

A) the crop **B)** the genetic information

C) the variety **D)** the insurance

3. According to paragraph 3, all of the following are reasons the location was chosen EXCEPT:

A) The ground stays frozen all year.

B) It is high above sea level.

C) It is close to most of the countries that send seeds.

D) It provides natural cooling.

4. The word “withdraw” in paragraph 4 is closest in meaning to:

A) protect **B)** take out

C) exchange **D)** donate

5. What can be inferred from paragraph 4 about the seed bank near Aleppo?

A) It was larger than the Svalbard vault.

B) It could no longer operate safely because of the war.

C) It sold its seeds to Lebanon and Morocco.

D) It was the first seed bank ever built.

Grammar in the Text

Answer the questions about the grammar used in the text. Choose the best option or write your answer on the lines.

6. Find it. Paragraph 4 contains an example of ellipsis after an auxiliary verb. Copy it and write the words that were left out.

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7. Find the mistake. Paragraph 5 contains one article mistake. Find it and correct it.

Mistake: _____ Correction: _____

8. Choose. In paragraph 3, why are there commas around “where the ground stays frozen all year”?

A) The clause is essential to identify which Svalbard.

B) The clause gives extra, non-essential information.

C) The clause is a condition.

D) The clause shows contrast with the main sentence.

9. Rewrite. Rewrite using **so that**, keeping the meaning: “The tunnel was repaired and made waterproof lest a similar flood happen again.”

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10. Same meaning. “Svalbard provides natural cooling, albeit not quite enough” (paragraph 3). *Albeit* means:

A) because **B)** so that

C) unless **D)** although

TEXT 3 — IS FOUR DAYS ENOUGH?

[1] For more than a century, the five-day working week has been treated almost as a law of nature. Yet it is a fairly recent invention. Before the 1920s, most factory workers had worked six days a week, often for ten hours a day. In 1926, the car manufacturer Henry Ford, who wanted his workers to have time to spend their wages, reduced their schedule from six days to five. Today, a growing number of companies are asking a question that Ford would have recognized: what would happen if people worked less but produced the same?

[2] The largest test so far took place in the United Kingdom in 2022, when 61 companies agreed to try a four-day week for six months. Each company chose its own system: some closed on Fridays, while others gave employees different days off. Employees kept their full salaries, but they had to maintain their usual productivity. Before the trial started, the organizers had trained managers to cancel unnecessary meetings and to protect time for focused work. Researchers from several universities collected data throughout the trial. By the end of the six months, 56 of the 61 companies had decided to continue, and 18 had already made the change permanent.

[3] The results were striking. Most employees reported feeling less stressed, and many said they slept better than they had before the trial. Some used their extra day for hobbies, sport or family, while others simply rested. The number of sick days fell by about two-thirds. Interestingly, company revenue barely changed, which suggests that people were not working less effectively. "Our team has never been happier," said the director of a small marketing agency. "If we had known how well it worked, we would start years ago."

[4] Not everyone is convinced, however. Critics point out that the companies in the trial volunteered to take part, so they were probably more enthusiastic about the idea than an average business would be. They also note that most of them were small offices. Hospitals, schools and restaurants cannot simply close for an extra day; they would need to hire more staff in order that their services could remain open, and that would be expensive. Some economists also worry that the benefits may disappear once the novelty wears off. Office workers can often reorganize their tasks to fit into four days. Nurses and teachers usually cannot.

[5] Perhaps the real lesson is not about the number of days but about how time is used. Many of the companies in the trial discovered that they had been wasting hours on activities that added very little value, such as long reports that nobody read. Trying a shorter week forced them to stop doing those things. If Ford hadn't questioned the six-day week a hundred years ago, many of us would probably still be working on Saturdays. The four-day week may never suit every profession. Whether or not it becomes the norm, though, it has already forced employers to think about work more carefully than they have in decades.

Reading Comprehension

Choose the best answer (A, B, C or D) according to the text.

1. According to paragraph 1, why did Henry Ford reduce his workers' schedule?

A) To cut the company's costs

B) So that workers had time to spend their wages

C) Because the law required it

D) Because his factories were producing too many cars

2. Which of the following is true about the UK trial, according to paragraph 2?

A) All companies closed on Fridays.

B) Employees received lower salaries.

C) Managers were trained before the trial began.

D) Most companies stopped the four-day week afterward.

3. The word "striking" in paragraph 3 is closest in meaning to:

A) violent **B)** disappointing

C) expected **D)** remarkable

4. What do the critics in paragraph 4 suggest about the trial results?

A) They may not represent typical businesses.

B) They were invented by the researchers.

C) They prove the four-day week works everywhere.

D) They show that hospitals benefit most.

5. Which statement best expresses the author's main point in paragraph 5?

A) Ford's decision was a mistake.

B) How time is used matters more than the number of days worked.

C) The four-day week will soon become the norm.

D) Employees should work on Saturdays.

Grammar in the Text

Answer the questions about the grammar used in the text. Choose the best option or write your answer on the lines.

6. **Find the mistake.** The quotation in paragraph 3 contains one conditional mistake. Find it and correct it.

Mistake: _____ Correction: _____

7. **Same meaning.** Which sentence has the same meaning as "If Ford hadn't questioned the six-day week a hundred years ago, many of us would probably still be working on Saturdays" (paragraph 5)?

A) Ford questioned the six-day week, so most of us probably don't work on Saturdays now.

B) Ford didn't question the six-day week, so we still work on Saturdays.

C) If Ford questions the six-day week, we will stop working on Saturdays.

D) Ford questioned the six-day week, but we still work on Saturdays.

8. **Rewrite.** Rewrite in the passive, keeping the past perfect: "Before the trial started, the organizers had trained managers to cancel unnecessary meetings."

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9. **Same meaning.** "Trying a shorter week forced them to stop doing those things" (paragraph 5). Which sentence keeps this meaning?

A) They stopped to write long reports. **B)** They stopped writing long reports.

C) They stopped for writing long reports. **D)** They stopped write long reports.

10. **Rewrite.** Join the last two sentences of paragraph 4 into one sentence, using **whereas** and ellipsis.

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